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KARNATAKA

SIDDA'S CASTE RESORT

By Ajay Sukumaran

An embattled chief minister, the Enforcement Directorate (ED) looming in the background, a contentious caste census and high-stakes bypolls. There's a potent mix of cards at play in Karnataka, confounding the clamour by Opposition parties for CM Siddaramaiah's resignation in the wake of a Lokayukta investigation into *l'affaire* MUDA (Mysore Urban Development Authority)—the allegation that his wife, Parvathi B.M., had sought to make a windfall gain from an allotment of housing plots by the authority. A distraction, which can metastasise into the main course, looms in the shape of a caste count: a decade-old census has been pulled out from cold storage, with Siddaramaiah resolving to place it before his cabinet for discussion this month. All of it will come to a head as the campaign picks up for the assembly bypolls in Sandur, Shiggaon and Channapatna, which the Election Commission has scheduled for November 13.

First, the matter of the caste census report, the fruit of an initiative originally commissioned by Siddaramaiah in 2014 during his first term. Designed as a door-to-door survey to assess the socio-economic and educational position of backward classes in the state, it ran into opposition from dominant communities such as the Veerashaiva-Lingayats and Vokkaligas when a purported leak of findings in 2016 suggested their populations were much lower

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE